

PepsiCo x Purdue UX

DESIGN DOCUMENTATION

UXD Experience Studio | Fall 2026 | TEAM 09

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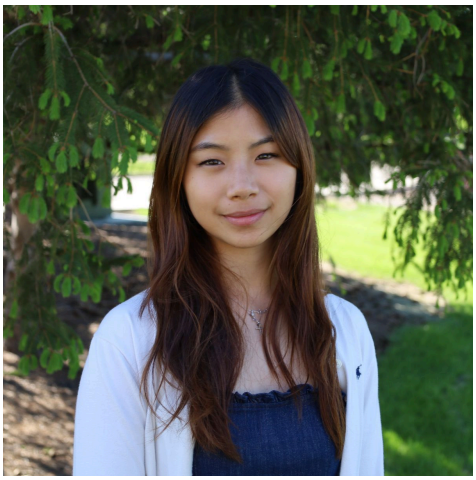
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Meet The Team



Ani Berry is a junior at Purdue University studying User Experience Design and Psychology. With a background in data visualization and marketing communications as well as proficiency in front-end web development and design, she brings key technical and design skills to projects. Ani hopes to specialize in visual design while learning more about artificial intelligence and UX research to deepen her understanding of user behavior. She also has interests in branding, digital marketing, and design research.



Jocelyn Chan is a Junior at Purdue University pursuing a degree in User Experience (UX) Design, with a minor in Psychology. Having just begun her journey in UX Design, she has spent a lot of time dabbling in Adobe Suite. She is passionate about creating the best experience for the consumer given her previous studies in hospitality, this allows her to enhance her understanding of customer relations and design with empathy. She is interested in product design and using a problem solving mindset she aims to focus on creating products that are intuitive and enjoyable for the user.



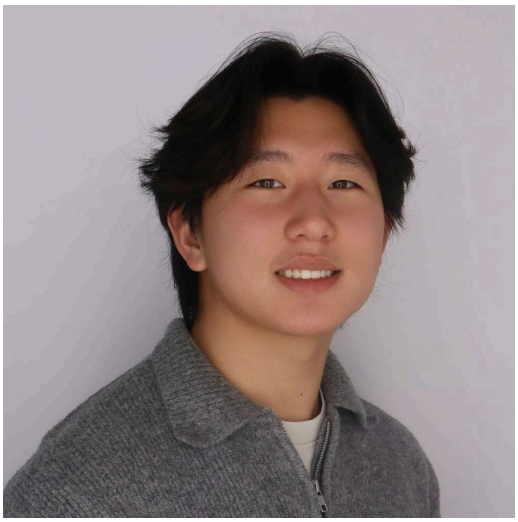
Christina Hittle is a sophomore at Purdue University majoring in UX Design with minors in Dance and Psychology. Originally from Maine, she brings a strong creative background and a growing interest in technology to her work in design. Through her academic experiences, Christina is developing skills in user research, wireframing, and prototyping, with a focus on creating intuitive, user-centered experiences. She is passionate about exploring how creativity and movement-informed thinking can influence thoughtful, human-centered design solutions.



Drew Lehner is attending Purdue University and is currently a sophomore studying User Experience Design with minors in Psychology and Marketing. Seeking to combine his creative background with his technological skills, UX is the perfect field. Drew is interested in creating frictionless, accessible designs for all people through human centered design. He hopes to one day make complicated systems and interfaces easy to use for people of all technical backgrounds. With an interest in the psychological side of UX, Drew is excited to study how human behaviors intertwine with technology. So far, he has become proficient in tools like Figma and Photoshop, as well as HTML and CSS.



Jun Hyok Lim is a Junior at Purdue University pursuing a bachelor's degree in User Experience Design. He is passionate about creating intuitive, user-centered digital experiences and loves using his creativity and analytical thinking to solve complex design challenges and improve user interactions. Currently, he is particularly interested in specializing in interaction design and product design, where he can craft seamless, engaging experiences that bridge functionality and aesthetics. He's also focused on improving his communication and leadership skills to collaborate effectively with teams and drive projects forward. Outside of class, he works on improving his skills by learning tools like Figma and Adobe and is constantly exploring new ways to enhance his expertise.
Portfolio |LinkedIn | Email



Ashton Sun is a junior majoring in UX Design and minoring in Anthropology. Pursuing a career in product design, he wants to contribute meaningful work across the entire process, from UX research to front-end development. He is curious about implementing AI intentionally, both in his workflow and in products. He previously interned as a Design Consultant at Ernst & Young, redesigning workflows and modernizing design systems for a healthcare financing company serving millions of patients. You may find Ashton in the pool, having been a lifelong competitive swimmer, or at a cafe building side projects.
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Company Description

PepsiCo is a global food and beverage company with a portfolio of well-known brands across snacks, beverages, and nutrition, serving consumers in markets around the world. The company operates at a large scale, combining manufacturing, distribution, marketing, technology, and digital services to support its products and business operations.

Project Description

PepsiCo's **JOY rewards system** is an existing consumer-facing loyalty platform serving European Union markets. JOY allows users to participate in promotions, redeem rewards, and receive prizes and discounts via a web-based experience. PepsiCo is seeking to improve the overall user experience of the web-based rewards and redemption flow, explore meaningful ways artificial intelligence can be incorporated, and establish a themable design system that can be adapted across PepsiCo's broader brand portfolio (e.g., Pepsi, Lay's, Doritos, 7UP, etc.).

User Group/Stakeholders

Primary

Digitally savvy PepsiCo European Union consumers (college-age users from 18-24)
This user group is very large, however, we will be able to scope down further into the project having conducted initial research. We acknowledge that our user group is in Europe while we are located in the US. We plan to recognize this as a limitation, whilst doing our best to find European participants to interview and test with.

Stakeholders

Pepsico sponsors
Our sponsors will oversee and provide feedback for the team throughout the research and design process. We will hand over the final research report and design files to the sponsors.

Problem Statement

As consumer expectations for digital loyalty experiences continue to rise, the JOY EU platform has an opportunity to evolve through **smarter design and AI integration**. Users who find redemption flows **confusing, impersonal, or effortful** are likely to **disengage** entirely. Beyond the immediate UX improvements, PepsiCo sees an opportunity to build a flexible, scalable foundation where the JOY platform's AI-enhanced experience can be rebranded and deployed across multiple PepsiCo properties without rebuilding from scratch.

Project Goal

- Conduct user research to identify pain points and opportunities to enhance engagement in the current JOY EU web rewards and redemption flow
- Design and prototype an improved JOY web experience that incorporates AI-driven features
- Develop a themeable design system that allows the experience to be reskinned for different PepsiCo brands
- Deliver actionable recommendations PepsiCo can use to inform future product development

Guiding Question:

How might we redesign the current consumer-facing loyalty program to improve the overall user experience of the web-based rewards and redemption flow while integrating AI in this journey?

Project Outcomes

The project will result in a redesigned and AI-enhanced rewards system experience that is intuitive, personal, and easy to use for Pepsico customers. The outcome includes an interactive web prototype of the redesigned JOY EU experience utilizing an established themeable design system that can be used across all Pepsico brands.

Projected Deliverables

Our final deliverables will highlight key design outputs and selected research insights.

1. High-fidelity Desktop Web Prototype

Interactive web prototype of the redesigned JOY EU experience utilizing established design systems.

2. Themable Design System

Themable design system with documented guidelines and at least two brand theme demonstrations.

3. Research Report

Research report including user insights, usability findings, and AI integration recommendations.

Phase 1: Research & Discovery

Goal

Assess the current reporting experience to uncover pain points and opportunities.

Guiding Question:

What are the key user needs, pain points, and the system constraints within the current app?

Outcomes

Gain primary and secondary research data to inform our ideation phase

- List of pain points, usage, and areas of improvement
- Problem framing and user need statements

1.1 Literature Review

Purpose

The purpose of the literature review was to learn about the principles in the reward systems and how those principles could be applied to the joy experience.

Approach

Our team reviewed articles and research related to reward systems and loyalty programs. We started by learning about general reward system principles and as we moved on, we continued to add more topics that we think would support our research.

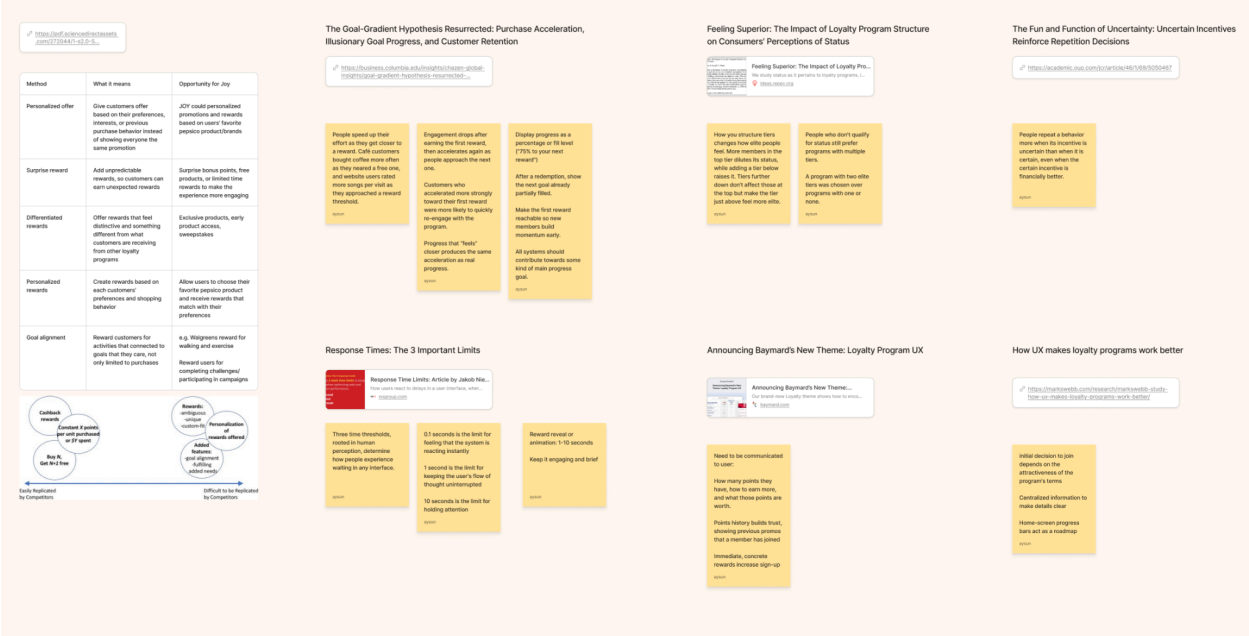


Fig. 1: Affinity diagram from our literature review in Figjam.

Outcome

References

Summary

Across six sources, one idea that came up repeatedly was that reward systems were effective when users clearly understood their progress and what they needed to do next.

Visible progress can encourage continued effort [1][5] while clear point values and activity history help build those trust [4][5]. Immediate feedback after completing an action made the overall experience more rewarding [3][6]. The research also showed that the motivation changes over time when users redeem a reward [1] and the features that attract the users to join the program may be different from the ones that keep them engaged [3][4][5]. Tier systems can motivate the users, but the effectiveness depends on how the tier system is structured [2].

Key Insights

> Once we understood what a good reward experience should include, we wanted to see whether the current joy experience follows those principles.

1.2 Heuristic Evaluation

Purpose

The purpose of heuristic evaluation is to identify usability issues in the current joy rewards before making any design and identify areas that make it harder for users to complete registration, find promotions, participate in active rewards, and understand what happens after every action.

Approach

Our team performed a heuristic evaluation on the current Joy Rewards platform. We used **Nielson's 10 usability heuristics** to note down any violations that we noticed. We then affinity diagrammed the violations based on the heuristic to identify any common patterns.

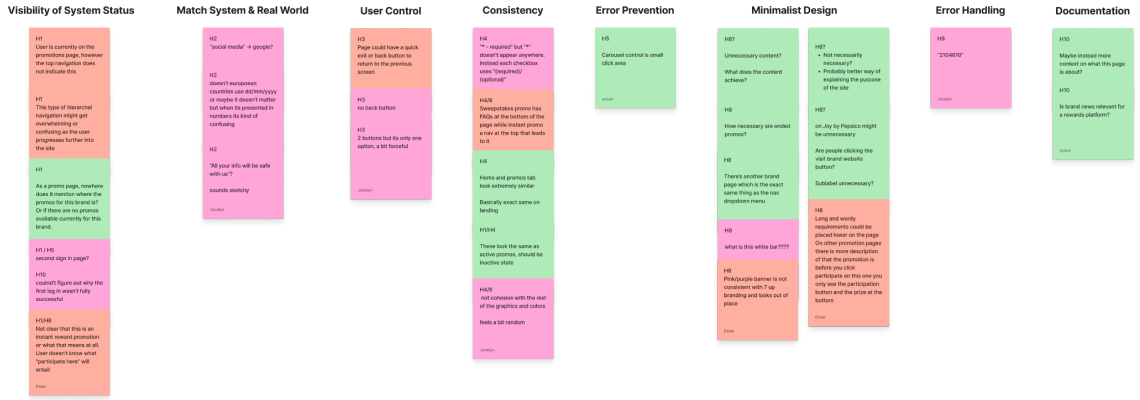


Fig. 2: Affinity diagram from our Heuristic Evaluation in Figjam.

Outcome

Summary

From the evaluation, we found repeated issues around **navigation**, **promotion structure**, **unnecessary content**, **wordy information**, and **system feedback**. Users are not able to see what pages they were on or how to return to the previous page. Some pages include long requirements before showing the prize or explaining how to participate. Expired promotions were also shown in a similar way as active ones.

Key Insights

- The navigation doesn't clearly show the user's current page. For example, the promotion tab doesn't appear selected when users are on the promotion page.
- Returning to home required users to click on the Joy logo which may not be obvious for some users.
- Some promotions showed "participate here" before explaining what this promotion is and what users can win.
- Active and expired promotions look similar that made it difficult to find the available ones.
- Some promotion pages use colors and graphics that do not match the brand such as a pink & purple design for the 7UP promotion.

Key Pain Points

- No clear home or back button
- May not know which pages they are currently on
- A second sign-in appears without explaining why the first sign-in was unsuccessful
- Long promotion requirements appear before explaining what the prize is and how to participate
- Expired promotions were in the promotion page and look similar to active promotions
- Instant promotions do not clearly explain that the result will be immediate after users participate
- Surveys appear directly after an instant loss which may result in a negative outcome

> Our heuristic evaluation allowed us to identify key usability concerns regarding clarity, feedback, consistency, and navigation. To understand how these issues actually affect users, we moved into cognitive walkthrough to learn how people interact with the current experience.

1.3 Cognitive Walkthrough

Purpose

The purpose of the cognitive walkthrough is to gain insight on user understanding of JOY EU rewards programs and identify redesign opportunities based on pain points users experience through interacting with the program.

Approach

Our team paired up to record cognitive walkthroughs with **3 UX students aged between 18-24**. We instructed participants to perform three tasks, covering JOY Rewards onboarding, promo/brand navigation, and redemption. We then used the transcription and pulled key insights from cognitive walkthroughs using AI (Claude).

See cognitive walkthrough protocol, tasks, and AI prompts here.

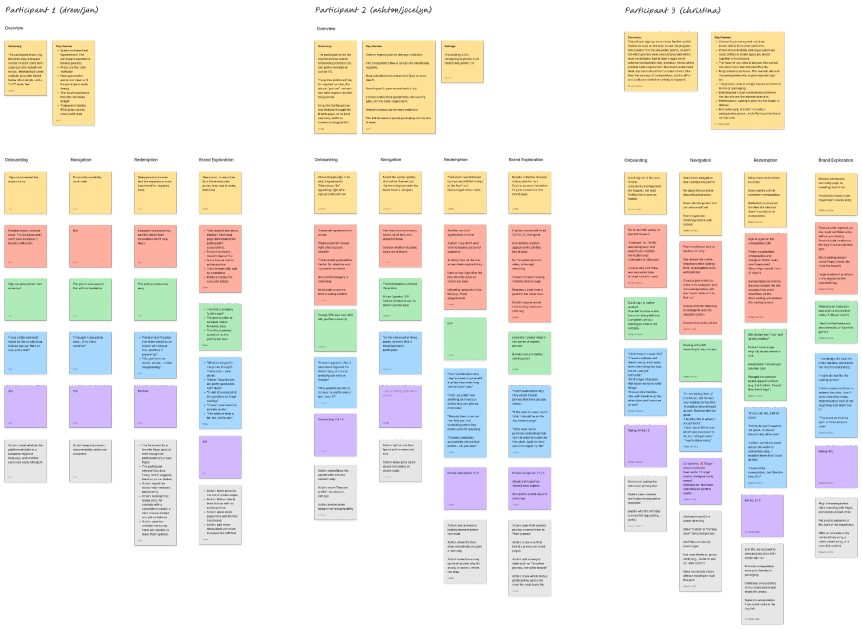


Fig. 3: Cognitive Walkthrough notes by participant & task in Figjam.

Outcome

Summary

Across all 3 participants, JOY rewards were easy to understand at first, but it became more difficult once they started to browse for active promotions and try to redeem them. Quick sign-ins and attractive prizes were effective, but expired promotions, unclear prize info, and external sweepstakes sites created confusion and frustration for participants.

Onboarding	Redemption	Brand Exploration
		

Key Insights

- Sign-up was quick and easy, but limited sign-in options to facebook and google.
- Participants were most intrigued when they saw available prizes.
- They wanted to see prizes first before they participated in promotions. (Prizes were the main motivator)
- Couldn't tell the difference between sweepstakes, instant win promotions, and coin rewards.

Key Pain Points

- Some promotions were expired but they were still shown on the promotion page.
- Some brand pages showed unrelated promotions or didn't show active promotions.
- Some participants had difficulty navigating to the promotions that they were looking for.
- Participants had to sign in again when a promotion opened on a separate sweepstakes website.
- After losing instantly, they felt disappointed and lost interest especially when they were asked to complete a survey right after.
- Even after signing in, participants had to go through additional agreements and verification steps which made the overall experience more complicated and longer.

Opportunities for Joy Rewards

> The cognitive walkthrough showed us where users hesitated, became confused, and their expectations with the current system. These findings led us to question what users actually expect from the reward program.

1.4 User Interviews

Purpose

User Interviews allow us to gain a better understanding of how the key users' mental model on rewards programs. What motivates them to sign up and stay consistent with the program, and what are common favorable brands that work for the users. Additionally, the interviews allow us to see when the user disengages and the common pain points that have been presented.

Approach

Our team recorded interviews with **users between the ages of 18-24**. We interviewed participants from both the **US and the UK**. We then used the transcription and pulled key insights from interviews using AI (Claude). We affinity diagrammed the insights in Figjam by key insights, relevant quotes, pain points, brands mentioned, and opportunities.

See interview protocol, AI prompts, and questions here.



Fig. 4: Interview notes affinity diagrammed in Figjam.

Outcome

Summary

Across all six interviews, participants had joined many reward programs, but were actively using few of them. Key programs mentioned included:

US Rewards: Starbucks rewards, Subway, 7 Brew, McDonald's, Chick-fil-A, Chipotle, Pacsun.
UK Rewards: Tesco Clubcard, Costa Coffee, Boots, Sainsbury's Nectar, Lidl Plus.

From both US and UK rewards, participants preferred rewards that were easy to understand, quick to earn, and clearly worth the time and effort. Immediate benefits such as free items (Costa's 10th drink free) and discounts (Tesco's instant half price) were more appealing than saving large amounts of points over time. Also, participants lost interest when rewards required too much spending, extra steps, and unclear rules that they had to follow. They didn't mind whether the reward program was run by the parent company or brand as long as they got the reward they wanted.

Key Insights

- Participants preferred rewards that they could receive within a few purchases instead of saving a large amount of points
- Clear system messages such as "buy 9, get the 10th free" were easier to understand than large point balances
- Users mostly earned rewards from purchases that they were already planning to buy
- Sign-up discounts attracted participants at first, but ongoing rewards were needed to keep them active

Key Pain Points

- Some programs required too much spending before they could spend them
- Some participants were not aware when their points or coupons expire
- Small rewards didn't feel worth the time and effort
- Manual steps such as entering codes, scanning receipts, or completing daily check-ins reduce their motivation to stay active
- Users forgot about rewards when they were not clearly visible at the checkout

Opportunities for Joy Rewards

- Display both the joy coin balance and its dollar value
- Show progress like “200 more coins until _____ reward”
- Keep point expiration dates near the balance, “You have points expiring soon”
- Separate rewards into categories such as discounts, sweepstakes, and instant win/loss
- Add rewards for existing members

> Throughout the interviews, we learned which rewards users valued the most, what kept them engaging, and which reward programs that they enjoyed the most. We took programs that were commonly mentioned to review what those programs are doing effectively and differently.

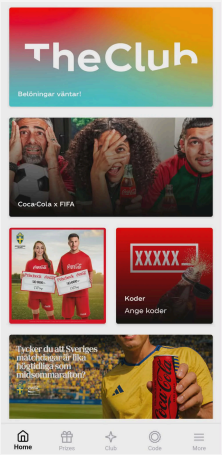
1.5 Competitive Analysis

Purpose

The purpose of the competitive analysis is to understand how other brands structure their rewards programs and attract new users and keep them engaged. This allowed our team to learn about their strengths and weaknesses and identify opportunities to improve the joy rewards experience.

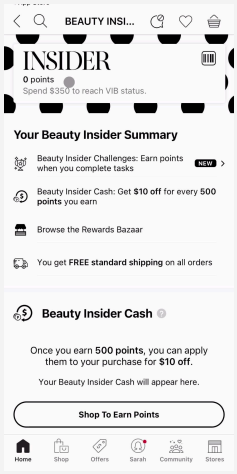
Approach

Our team performed a competitive analysis on a total of **7 brands.** Each was chosen under the reasoning that the brands were either similar to Pepsi, hold multiple subbrands, or were common brands mentioned in user interviews. The activity was performed with a SWOT analysis looking into its **Strengths, Weakness, Opportunities and Threats.**



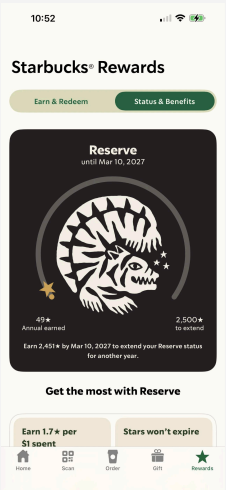
Coca-Cola: The Club (GB)

S	Clear three-tier progression and point thresholds encourage users to come back.
W	No clear "points per dollar" - a 500ml bottle earns the same 50 points regardless of price paid.
O	Publish reward catalogs with fixed point costs to build trust and compete against fixed-value loyalty programs.
T	The 90-day reset for points is aggressive and can negatively pressure users.



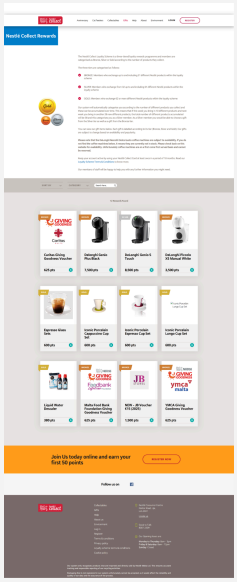
Sephora: Beauty Insider Program (US)

S	Offers multiple ways to earn points, and points can be redeemed in varying ways. The tier structure also rewards high spenders with exclusive discounts.
W	Reward thresholds can feel disproportionate for users: a mid-tier physical reward requires about $750 in spend. Some challenges are gated behind purchases while others are free.
O	Points and events could be segmented by brand (similar to Joy's model) to personalize the experience. Highlighting free challenges such as in-store shade matching could also broaden participation.
T	Discounts for users in higher tiers can promote exclusivity and alienate casual buyers.



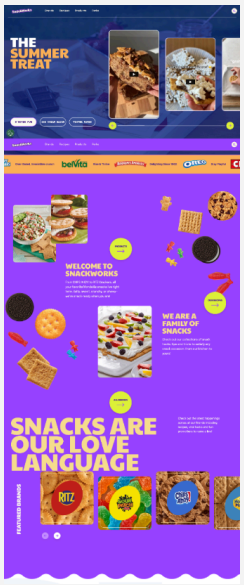
Starbucks: Rewards (US)

S	Frequent, achievable bonus challenges and higher earn rates for preferred payment methods encourage repeat visits. Clear Green, Gold, and Reserve tiers and visible progress, including star requirements for each tier, make goals feel attainable.
W	Status & Benefits screens are information-dense and hard to scan on a mobile screen. Multiple earning mechanisms may leave new users unsure which action is most valuable.
O	Student-centric rewards, social features such as gifting/group orders, personalization using AI (e.g. using purchase history, weather data, or time of day to recommend certain items)
T	Casual users may disengage from reward fatigue if tracking feels like more effort than the rewards are worth for them.



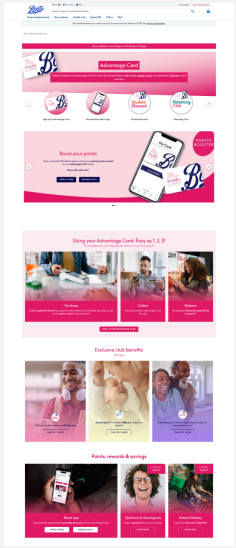
Nestlé: Collect Rewards (Malta)

S	Tier systems are explained clearly before users browse rewards. Intuitive search, category filters, and sorting make active rewards easy to find, and reward cards include visible tier and point labels.
W	Buttons, alignments, and colors are inconsistent across pages, and the visual hierarchy is weak, which raises cognitive load. First-time users must scroll to the bottom to see available rewards, and the introductory section is text-heavy and hard to scan.
O	Implementation of a more consistent design system with stronger visual hierarchy, displaying progress toward the next reward, and reordering sections with key information.
T	Because the visual hierarchy is weak and the sections contain text that is hard to scan, users may abandon the site due to confusion.



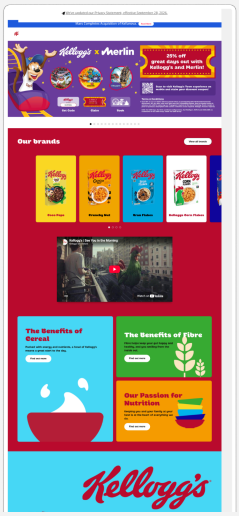
Snack Works: Perks Rewards Program (US)

S	Users can choose between sweepstakes, raffles, and cash-back, so the program caters to different motivations and gives several ways to engage and be rewarded.
W	It's uncertain whether the fees paid to outside program hosts are offset by a corresponding increase in product demand. The site is information-dense and may be difficult for first-time users to navigate.
O	A points-based cash-back structure, direct redemption for physical products, and membership tiers could make rewards feel more immediate and encourage long-term engagement. Simplifying the site's structure with clearer navigation can make content easier to find.
T	Similar to PepsiCo, there is no clear strategy for keeping users engaged beyond the initial reward or redemption. Once a user loses, they may disengage with the program.



Boots: Advantage Card Rewards (UK)

S	The program has clear reward values, is free to join, and offers an immediate signup incentive. Rewards are tailored to different groups, such as students, over-60s, and parents. The page also follows a logical layout that introduces core benefits first before revealing secondary rewards.
W	Various brands included in the program each have their own rewards programs, and some program benefits require additional verification.
O	A single dashboard could display all active rewards and eligible programs for the user. Savings could be shown more clearly, and program rules could be simplified.
T	Boots creates a stronger loyalty program across different user groups through programs for parents, seniors, and students. This could make joy reward feel less rewarding and less personalized if it offers same experience to all users.

	**Kellogg's: Family Rewards (UK)**	
	S	This program effectively engages visitors by displaying rewards on covers of promotion which acts as an incentive and encourages participation. The home and brand page also introduces the company and its range of brands, along with their benefits, products and new releases. The K-Town function also acts as an interactive and fun function for users to participate in.
	W	Entry for promotions are only limited to phones and several promotions don't work or don't appear. Some promotions are presented as links which makes the experience feel inconsistent. The Navigation is also unclear, without a dedicated home section.
	O	The brand pages expanded to include more information on the specific products and can give users more reason to explore. Showing rewards directly on each promotion would also give people a clearer incentive to take part.
	T	Mobile only availability is limiting. The use of an interactive town can also create frustration for users who want to enter the promotion, through the addition of clicks and through having to actively find the promotion a second time.

Outcome

Summary

Across the programs reviewed, those featuring clear tiers, transparent point values, visible progress tracking, and achievable short-term goals showed signs of stronger user motivation. In contrast, cluttered navigation and unclear value or expiration rules were associated with added complexity and occasional confusion.

Key Insights

- Clear tier systems with visible benefits give users a reason to keep going
- Simple tiers, visible progress toward the next level, and transparent point values keep users engaged.

- Offering several ways to earn (purchases, cash back, challenges, birthday rewards) can widen engagement.

Key Pain Points

- Crowded homepages, weak navigation, and too many competing promotions make it hard to know where to look.
- Chance-based rewards raise doubts about whether they drive purchasing compared with guaranteed points or cash back
- Programs that treat all members the same give little reason to keep engaging.

Opportunities for JOY Rewards

- Transparent rewards
- Simple tiers
- Engaging challenges

> The competitive analysis showed us common patterns across different reward programs and opportunities to design distinctive and unique systems for joy rewards. These findings would help us gain a clear foundation for ideation.

1.6 Research Synthesis

Purpose

Approach

Outcome

> The synthesis helped our team become aligned on major pain points, opportunities, and understanding of our project scope. We will take these research insights to inform our design concepts and decisions in the next phase.

Phase 2: Ideation & Prototyping

Goal

Establish design concepts and decisions informed by research. Utilize AI tools to generate rapid prototypes for testing and iteration.

Guiding Question:

How can we create and collect feedback on research informed design concepts that address our findings from Phase 1?

Outcomes

- Foundations for a themeable design system
- Sketches that portray multiple design directions
- AI-generated prototypes with actionable feedback
- Direction for high-fidelity prototypes

2.1 User Flows

Purpose

The purpose of the user flow is to map out the steps a user takes in completing activities within the Joy EU website. The task provides a visual representation of the user journey, identifying pain points that may prolong tasks and create frustration. Which will inform the designing process and help create an intuitive flow.

Approach

Through the feedback gathered from the cognitive walkthrough, our team created user flows based on the tasks performed by the participants. The tasks cover three key areas within Joy Rewards: onboarding, promo/brand navigation, redemption, and brand exploration. For each task we documented each page visited and action taken, and sequenced it into a flow the users follow from start to finish. Steps that showed frustration within the cognitive walkthrough were then noted for potential improvement.

Outcome

Within the four user flows, most showed a straightforward process in completing tasks. With navigation, redemption and brand exploration leading smoothly from page to page. The onboarding task showed a prolonged flow with the existence of a loop and slight navigation difficulties. By creating an ideal flow that eliminates pain points we were able to pinpoint actionable steps moving forward:

- Create clear instruction on necessary steps required of the user to eliminate the user from going back and forth between pages
- Condense necessary action into one page to eliminate the need to take users to another similar page after
- Onboarding should take users to the home page after completion

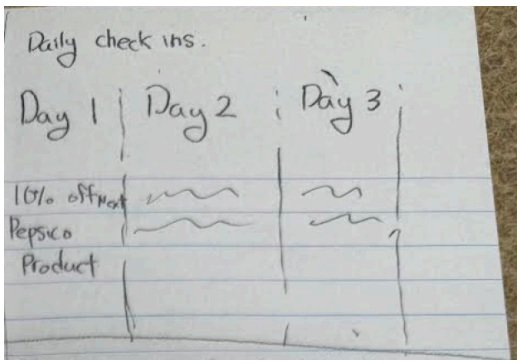
2.2 Sketches

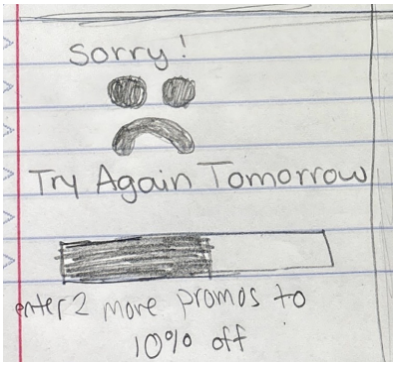
Purpose

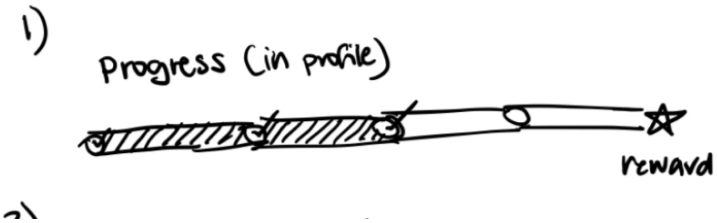
1. Generate a range of ideas based on key research insights and identified pain points
2. Explore concepts that could increase user engagement across JOY EU rewards experience
3. Narrow down to high-potential design directions to carry forward into wireframing and low fidelity prototyping

Approach

Our Team conducted Crazy 8s brainstorming activity. This allowed us to generate a high volume of concepts within a constrained time frame.









Once our sketches were complete, we grouped similar solutions and narrowed them into broader categories to identify recurring patterns within our ideation. After discussing as a team, we continued by conducting a voting activity within our group. Each team member received two votes for improvements to the existing JOY experience and two votes for concepts introducing new functionality. This process allowed us to move toward a smaller set of concepts with stronger team alignment and potential value moving forward.

Existing Promos	New Systems
Showing odds ★★★★	Dailys/Scheduled Rewards ★★★
History of Rewards	Birthday Rewards
Loading States ★★★★ • Wheel • Loading • Email	Coupon System
	Challenges ★★★★
	Bingo
Enter X amount of promos ★★★	Community ★★★★
Small rewards/Insignificant?	Points System Tiers

Outcome

We narrowed down initial sketches into potential features that we thought offered the strongest potential to improve the JOY EU rewards redemption flow. Following this activity,

we had a solid baseline for the next stage of the design process, where these concepts will be translated wireframes and evaluated through low-fidelity prototyping

Phase 3: Design & Prototype

Goal

Develop a high fidelity prototype that demonstrates an AI-enhanced redemption flow and usability findings. Apply and demonstrate themability of systems and conduct user testing.

Guiding Questions:

How might we create a refined high fidelity prototype adaptable to themability based on user feedback?

Outcomes

- Interactive web prototype of the redesigned JOY EU experience demonstrating AI enhancements
- Themable design system with documented guidelines and at least two brand theme demonstrations
- Research report including user insights, usability findings, and AI integration recommendations

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Appendix

Phases Outline

P1: Discovery & Research

Goal

Assess the current reporting experience to uncover pain points and opportunities.

Guiding Question:

What are the key user needs, pain points, and the system constraints within the current app?

Outcomes

Gain primary and secondary research data to inform our ideation phase

- List of pain points, usage, and areas of improvement
- Problem framing and user need statements

P2: Ideation & Prototyping

Goal

Establish design concepts and decisions informed by research. Utilize AI tools to generate rapid prototypes for testing and iteration.

Guiding Question:

How can we create and collect feedback on research informed design concepts that address our findings from Phase 1?

Outcomes

- Foundations for a themeable design system
- Sketches that portray multiple design directions
- AI-generated prototypes with actionable feedback
- Direction for high-fidelity prototypes

P3: Refinement & Finalization

Goal

Develop a high fidelity prototype that demonstrates an AI-enhanced redemption flow and usability findings. Apply and demonstrate themability of systems and conduct user testing.

Guiding Questions:

How might we create a refined high fidelity prototype adaptable to themability based on user feedback?

Outcomes

- Interactive web prototype of the redesigned JOY EU experience demonstrating AI enhancements

- Themable design system with documented guidelines and at least two brand theme demonstrations
- Research report including user insights, usability findings, and AI integration recommendations

Phase 1 Activities

Literature Review

- Literature on rewards system structure, retention, and design principles.

Heuristic Evaluation

- Understand opportunities to improve the existing interface using Nielson's 10 usability heuristics.

Cognitive Walkthrough

- Walk users through tasks on the existing platform to gain an understanding of pain points, usage, and areas of improvement.

User Interviews

- Conduct interviews with user groups to understand mental models on reward systems and their favorite platforms.

Competitive Analysis

- Identify the pros and cons of similar rewards programs.

Research Synthesis

- Synthesize all research yep

Phase 2 Activities

User Flow Mapping

- Map out current and prospective states of four main task flows on the current platform.

Sketching

- Develop early design concepts on opportunities to improve the existing rewards system.

Wireframing

- Group whiteboard wireframe main redesigned screens.

Design System Prototyping

- Prototype the foundations layer for the themeable design system using existing branding guidelines..

AI-Assisted Prototyping

- Reference our design system, sketches, and wireframes to generate early prototypes for redesigned screens.

Usability Testing & Iteration

- Test and iterate upon our AI-generated prototypes, A/B test specific features, layouts, and systems.

Phase 3 Activities

High-Fidelity Prototyping

- Utilizing established design systems and branding guidelines to prototype high-fidelity representations of the web experience.

Interview Protocol

Goals

- Understand users' mental models of how rewards programs work
- Understand what motivates initial sign-up vs. what sustains long-term use
- Understand what information users have vs. don't have when deciding whether a program is worth their time
- Understand how users perceive relationships between sub-brands under one parent company
- Understand expectations around a universal / cross-brand rewards system
- Identify common pain points across earning, tracking, and redeeming
- Identify the moments where users disengage or abandon a program entirely
- Identify user understanding of program terminology (points, tiers, status, redemption, member pricing, entries)
- Collect quantitative data on participants' current rewards experiences for benchmarking

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Process

Our team recorded interviews with **users between the ages of 18-24**, we then used the transcription and pulled key insights from interviews using the following prompt on **Claude**:

"You are analyzing a research/user interview transcript. Read the full transcript below and produce a structured analysis. Include a brief summary, key themes, pain points, relevant quotes, and a list of rewards platforms used by the interviewee. Include action items/implications if applicable. Format your response in a way that will be easy to transfer over to sticky notes on Figjam for affinity diagramming."

Each team member conducted 1-2 interviews, following the script below.

Script

Introduction

"Hello _____. Thank you so much for taking the time to speak with us. My name is _____, I am a student at Purdue trying to understand how people use and think about brand rewards programs. Your feedback and thoughts are incredibly valuable and will help guide our team's design decisions. Just to confirm, this interview is expected to last around 45 minutes, does this still work for you? Please be aware that there are no wrong answers and any information is useful — we're interested in your habits, not your knowledge.

Also, do I have your permission to record this interview? The recording will only be used to help revisit the answers you provide and won't be seen by anyone else. Your answers and responses will also be anonymous.

It's perfectly ok if you wish not to answer any of the questions, feel free to let me know and we can move on. (*If you would like to have closed captions on for this interview, we are able to turn that on as well.*)"

Questions

Participant profile

- Do you use any rewards or loyalty programs?
    - Roughly how many rewards or loyalty programs are you signed up for?
- How many of those would you say you actually use?
- When you hear "rewards program," what's the first one that comes to mind?

Favorite program

- Do you have a favorite rewards program?
- Which rewards program do you enjoy the most?
    - What makes it different from the others?
- What does it do that you wish other programs did?
- Tell me about the best reward you've gotten from it.
- How often do you think about this program?
    - Does it come to mind before you shop, or only at checkout?
- Do you do anything differently in order to earn? (e.g. pick a specific brand, buy a larger size, scan a receipt, enter a code from the packaging, shop on a certain day?)
- How do you know how close you are to a reward?
- Do you know if or when your points expire?
- Do you get notifications from this program?
    - Are they useful?
- Is there anything you've been saving toward?
- Has this program ever done something that annoyed you?
    - What was it?

Multi-brand & universal rewards

- Are you a member of any program that covers more than one brand?
    - How does it work?
- Do you think of a program like that as belonging to the parent company, or to the individual brands?
    - Does that distinction matter to you?

Retention & investment

- Tell me about a program you stopped using. What was the moment you checked out?
- Have you ever felt like a program wasn't worth the effort, or that it was asking too much of you?
    - Why so?

Europe Add-Ons

- Which country and city do you live in , and how long have you lived there?

- (lived outside EU) Where did you live before, and did you use rewards programs there?
- (lived outside EU) Which of the programs you mentioned today are from the Europe?
- (lived outside EU) How are rewards programs in the Europe different from others you've used?
    - What works better? What works worse?

Wrapping Up script

"Those were all the questions we wanted to ask you, and thank you so much for taking the time to answer them! We really appreciate your cooperation.

Is there anything else you would like to share?

If you could change one thing about any rewards program you use, what would it be?

Would we be able to reach out to you in the future to do any usability testing?

Have a great day!"

Cognitive Walkthrough Protocol

Goals

- Understand expectations around a universal / cross-brand rewards system
- Identify common pain points across earning, tracking, and redeeming
- Identify user understanding of program terminology (points, tiers, status, redemption, member pricing, entries)
- Collect quantitative data on participants' current rewards experiences for benchmarking

---

Process

Our team recorded cognitive walkthroughs with **users between the ages of 18-24**, we then used the transcription and pulled key insights from interviews using the following prompt on **Claude**:

"You are analyzing a cognitive walkthrough transcript. Read the full transcript below and produce a structured analysis. Categorize by each task, but also create a general universal overview. Include a brief summary, key themes, pain points, relevant quotes, and quantitative data. Include action items/implications if applicable. Format your response in a way that will be easy to transfer over to sticky notes on Figjam for affinity diagramming."

Script

Introduction

"Hello _____. Thank you so much for taking the time to speak with us. Our team wants to understand how people use the Joy rewards program from Pepsi. Your feedback and thoughts are incredibly valuable and will help guide our team's design decisions. Just to confirm, this walkthrough is expected to last around 30 minutes, does this still work for you? Please be aware that there are no wrong answers and any information is useful.

Also, do I have your permission to record this walkthrough? The recording will only be used to help revisit the answers you provide and won't be seen by anyone else. Your answers and responses will also be anonymous.

We will be focusing on a few tasks, please try to think out loud as you complete them, it's perfectly ok if you wish not to complete a task, feel free to let me know and we can move on."

Tasks

Creating an account

1. Navigate to the Joy Rewards platform, sign up for an account

Questions:

- On a scale of 1-5, with 1 being the worst and 5 being the best, how would you rate the current onboarding experience?
    - Why?

Look for specific promo

1. Try to find a specific promo: Pepsi YEAR OF LIVE MUSIC sweepstakes

Questions:

- On a scale of 1-5, with 1 being the worst and 5 being the best, how would you rate the experience of finding a promo?
    - Why?

Apply for instant sweepstakes promo

1. Apply for the promo and see if you won

Questions:

- On a scale of 1-5, with 1 being the worst and 5 being the best, how would you rate the current promo redemption experience?

    - Why?

Explore other brands?

1. Explore other brand pages to find any other promos?

Questions:

- On a scale of 1-5, with 1 being the worst and 5 being the best, how would you rate the brand exploration experience?
    - Why?

Wrapping Up script

"Those were all the questions we wanted to ask you, and thank you so much for taking the time to answer them! We really appreciate your cooperation.

Is there anything else you would like to share?

If you could change one thing about any rewards program you use, what would it be?

Would we be able to reach out to you in the future to do any usability testing?

Have a great day!"